USER GUIDE · FOR JUDGES

# Ballast

**Plan your week by how much it takes out of you, not how many hours it fills.**

😩 THE PROBLEM

Students burn out because planners count hours, not energy. A bad week is only noticed once it has already happened.

🎮 DEMO · NO LOGIN

**load-balancer-ballast--demo.expo.app**

A ready-made student week. Resets on every reload.

📱 THE REAL APP

**load-balancer-ballast.expo.app**

Sign in with a judge account (page 2) or your own.

## 👩‍⚖️ Judges' suggestions

**1 · Read this guide first.** It's short, and it makes the app quicker to pick up.

**2 · Start with the demo link.** Ballast works on each user's own week, so a new account starts empty. The demo is a mostly functional preview with a full, ready-made week. Explore it before creating your own brand-new account.

**3 · Try the social side with real accounts.** Our key social features need real people, so we set up **five real judge accounts** who are all friends. Open a few at the same time and follow **page 8**.

⚠️ **The five accounts are shared by every judge. Please play, but don't wreck them.**
✅ Go ahead: add tasks, mark classes, check in, book sittings, accept or decline plans, send invites, rebalance.
🚫 Please don't: **change the password**, **sign out other devices**, **delete groups**, **remove friends**, or **connect your own Google Calendar** to them.
If something does get messed up, we can rebuild all five in about a minute.

**Have fun!** 🎉

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30 SECONDS · NO APP STORE NEEDED

# Download & install

📱 THE APP

**load-balancer-ballast.expo.app**

Scan with your phone camera

🎮 DEMO · NO LOGIN

**load-balancer-ballast--demo.expo.app**

Resets on every reload

### 🍎 iPhone · Safari

1. Open the app link (or scan)
2. Tap **Share** ⬆ at the bottom
3. **Add to Home Screen** → **Add**
4. Open **Ballast** from your home screen

### 🤖 Android · Chrome

1. Open the app link (or scan)
2. Tap the menu ⋮ (top right)
3. **Install app** → **Install**
4. Open **Ballast** from your home screen

💻 On a laptop: any browser works. It's designed for phones, so a narrow window looks best.

ALL FRIENDS WITH EACH OTHER

# Judge accounts

Password for all five: `BallastDemo2026`

| STUDENT | EMAIL | THEIR WEEK | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| 💻 **Aisyah** | `aisyah.ballast@example.com` | A wall next week | Red wall → **Lighten** |
| 🧪 **Priya** | `priya.ballast@example.com` | Running on empty | **Recovery** |
| 📊 **Daniel** | `daniel.ballast@example.com` | Steady, barista shifts | **Plans** → **Sent** |
| 🏗️ **Hafiz** | `hafiz.ballast@example.com` | Design crunch | Birthday dinner answers |
| 🎨 **Mei Ling** | `meiling.ballast@example.com` | The calm one | Invites in the 🔔 |

⚠️ **Shared by every judge.** Please don't change the password, sign out other devices, delete groups, remove friends, or connect Google Calendar.

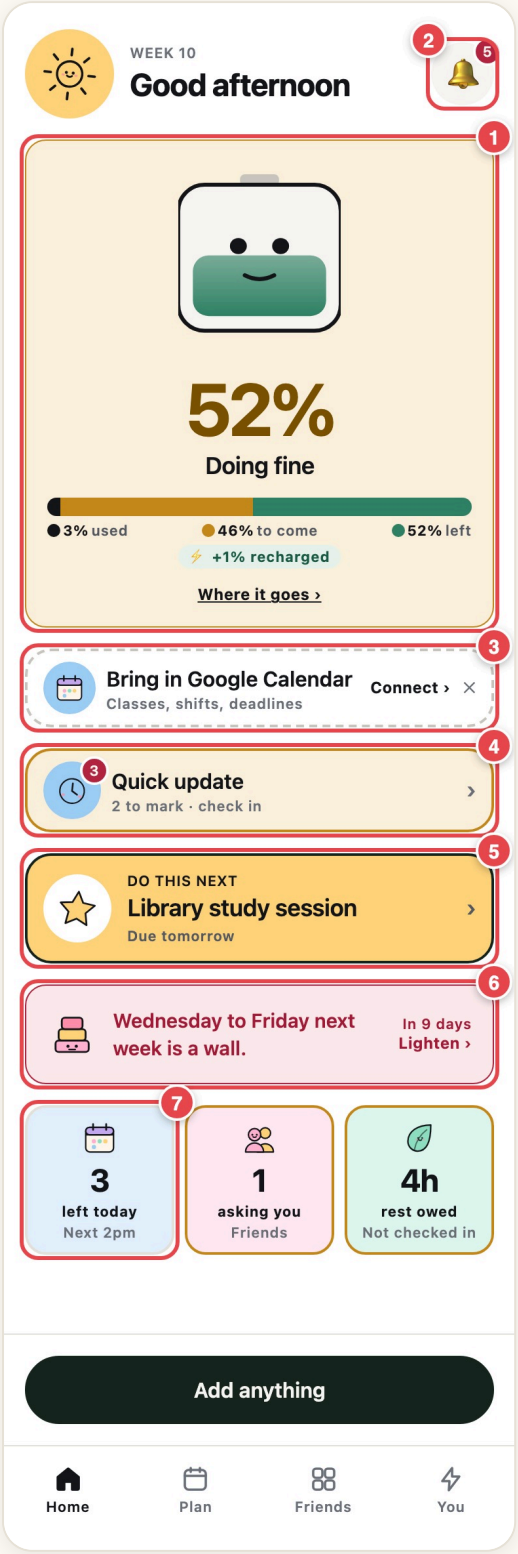
💡 **Want a blank slate?** Create your own account. Setup is four short steps, all skippable.

YOUR WHOLE WEEK IN ONE LOOK

# Home

**THE PROBLEM**

Planners show how many hours are booked, not how drained you'll be, so burnout is only noticed when it's too late.




1. **Your battery**
   100% each Monday. Every commitment takes a share.
2. **Bell**
   Invites, answers, deadlines
3. **Google Calendar**
   Bring your events in
4. **Quick update**
   Mark classes ✓ ✕, check in
5. **Do this next**
   From the priority list (page 6)
6. **The wall**
   A pile-up spotted days early → **Lighten**
7. **At a glance**
   Today, friends, rest owed

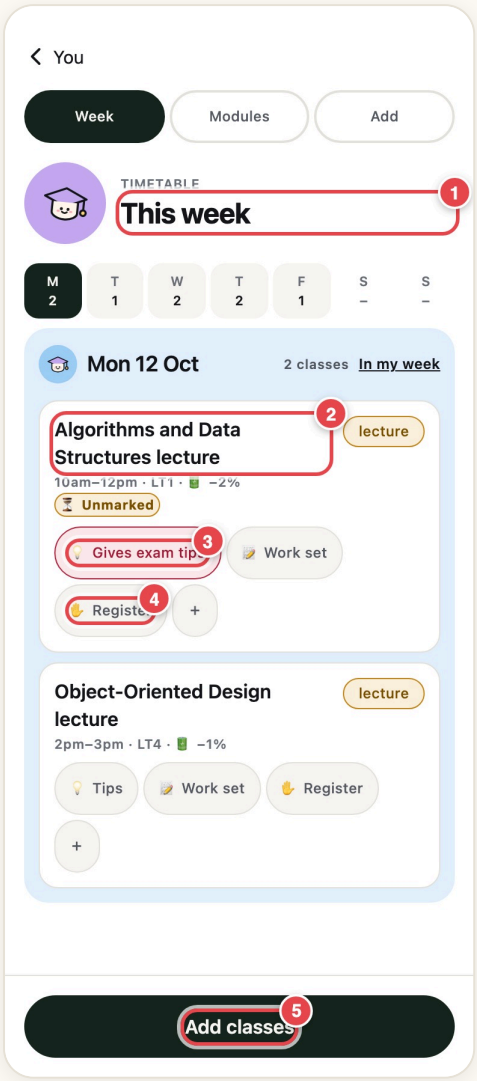
**Energy, not hours.** Two hours of a dreaded report cost more than two hours of badminton.

KEY FEATURE · CLASSES & ATTENDANCE

# Timetable

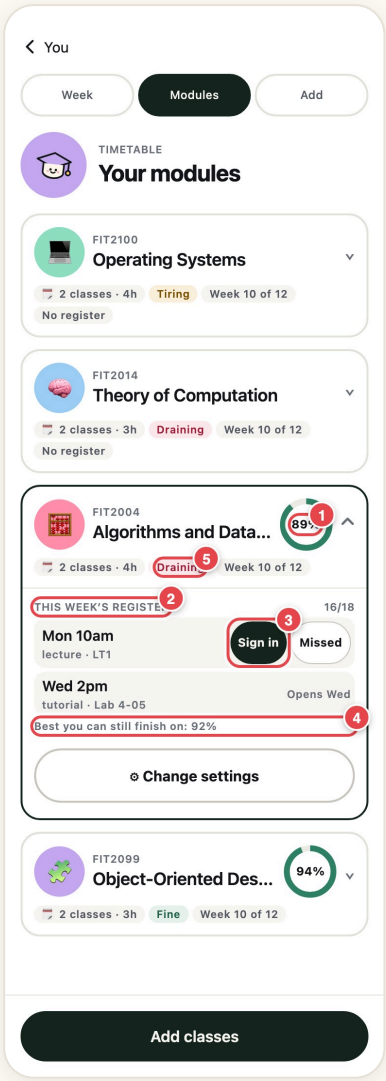
**THE PROBLEM**

Classes fill most of a student's week, yet planners treat them as plain events. They don't know which classes drain you, which ones count for attendance, or which ones give exam tips.




Week

1. **This week**, day by day
2. **Each class**
   With its battery cost
3. **Flags**
   Exam tips · work set. Tap to toggle.
4. **Register**
   Attendance counts here
5. **Add classes**




Modules

1. **Attendance so far**
2. **This week's register**
3. **Sign in / Missed**
   One tap after class
4. **Best you can still finish on**
5. **How draining**
   Sets each class's battery cost

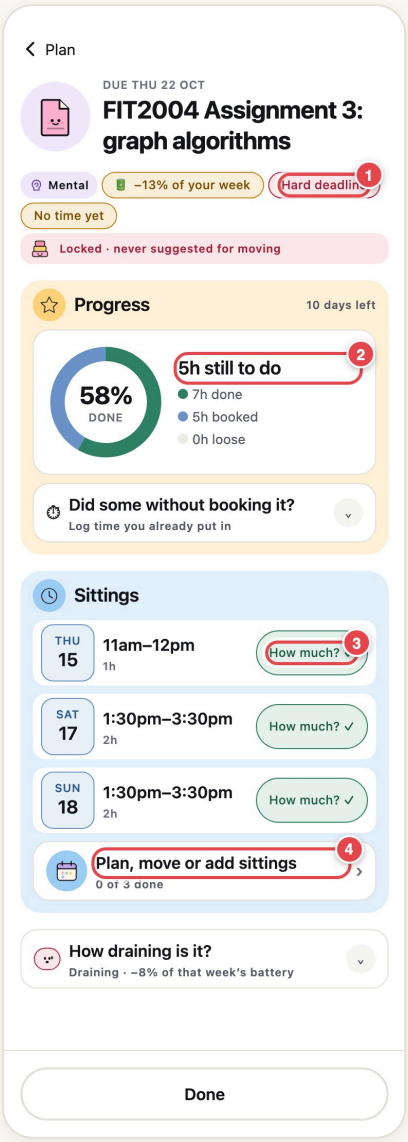
⚡ **Fast setup:** add a module, tap its days and times. Or **Paste from your portal** to bring the whole timetable in at once.

KEY FEATURE · ASSIGNMENTS AS HOURS OWED

# Owing work

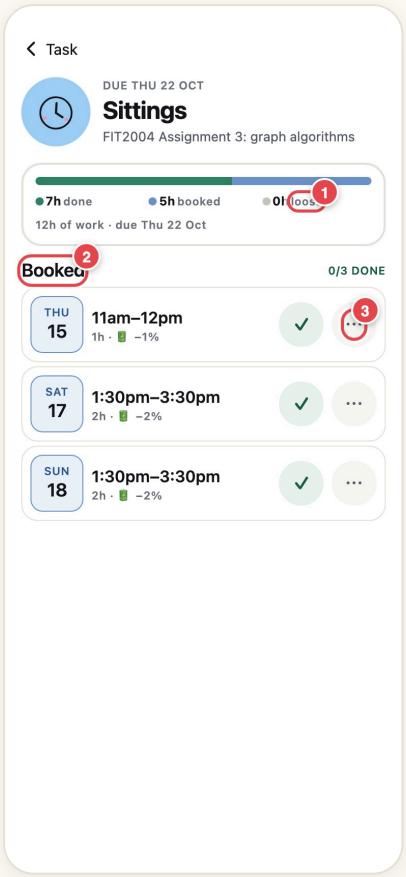
**THE PROBLEM**

An assignment isn't one event, it's hours of work you owe. Planners only note the deadline, so the work lands the night before.




The assignment

1. **Locked**
   Hard deadlines never move
2. **Progress**
   Done · booked · loose
3. **How much?**
   Log progress after a sitting
4. **Plan sittings**




Its sittings

1. **Done · booked · loose**
2. **Booked sittings**
   Each with its battery cost
3. **··· Move or give back**

### ✨ Suggest

Hours still loose? Ballast proposes sittings on your **lightest days**, each with a reason. Nothing is booked until you say so.

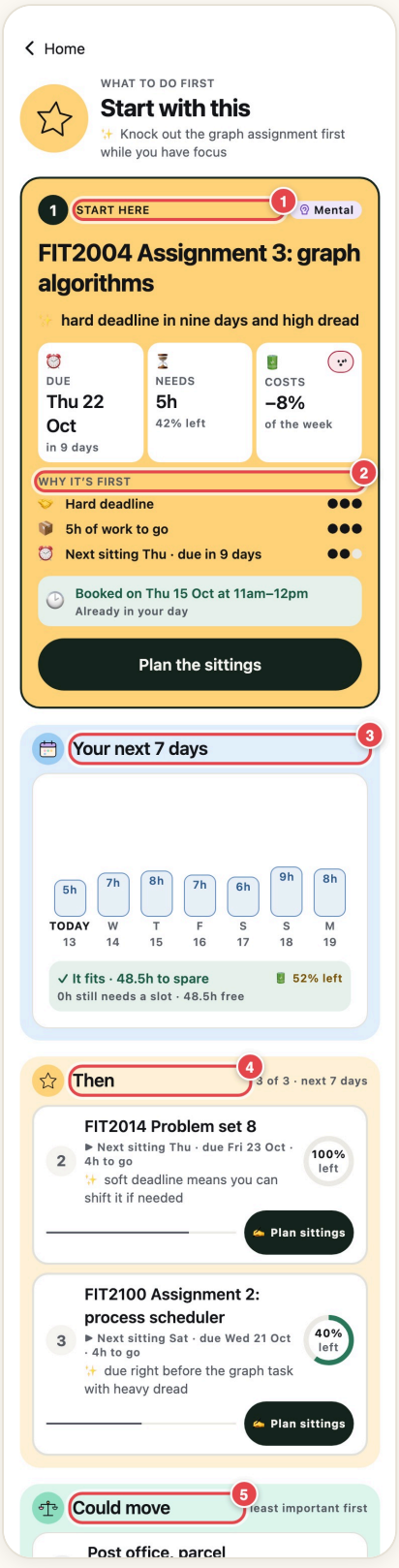
✍️ **Add one:** tap **Add anything** and type it how you'd say it: *"Networks report, Thursday, 5h, dreading it"*.

KEY FEATURE · WHAT TO DO FIRST

# Priority list

**THE PROBLEM**

With ten things due, students burn energy just deciding what to do first, and usually pick the easy thing.




1. **Start here**
   Due date, hours needed, battery cost
2. **Why it's first**
   Plain reasons, no guessing
3. **Your next 7 days**
   Hours needed vs. hours free
4. **Then**
   Owing work and tasks, in the order to **start** them
5. **Could move**
   Movable blocks, least important first, each with why

## How it ranks

By the day you have to **start**: walking back from the deadline through your real free time. So 12 hours due next week can come before 1 hour due tomorrow. Importance ( → ) decides within a day. Fixed plans never appear.

## AI headline

A line of advice on top and a short why on each row. The order itself comes from our own model, so it's explainable and stays the same each time.

## Change the time · Move it

One picker everywhere: this week and next with **how full each day is** (or a calendar), then **drag the block** along the day. **Move it** opens it as a pop-up, preset to a lighter slot.

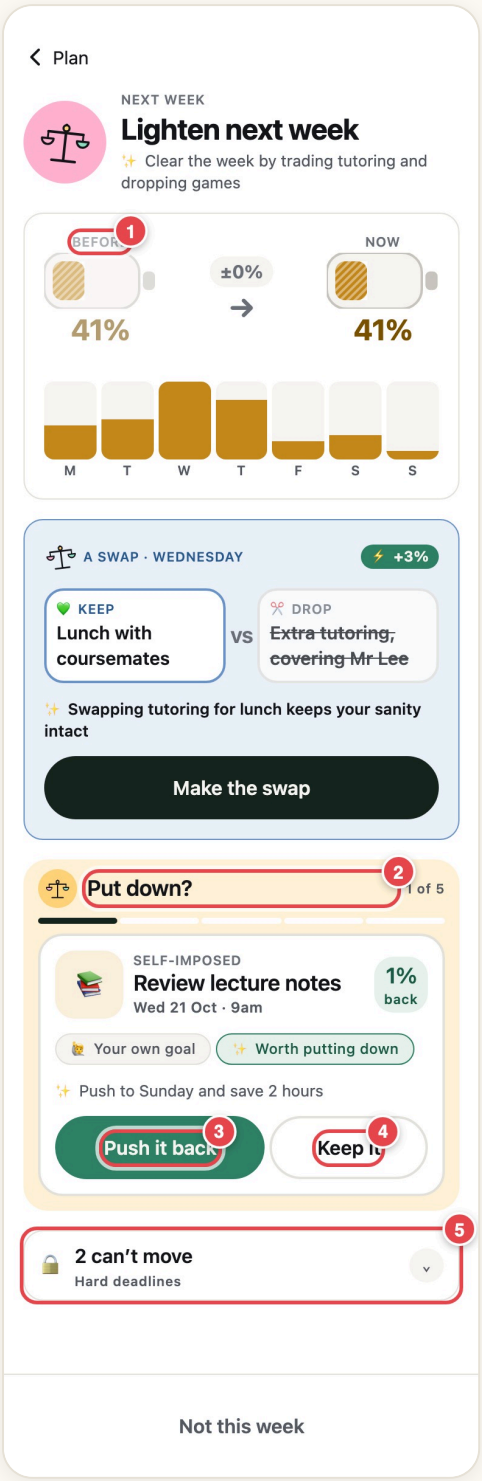
Find it: **Home** → **Do this next**, or **Plan** → **What to do first**.

TRADING, NOT DELETING

# Lighten next week

**THE PROBLEM**

When a week is too much, people cancel at random, often the wrong thing, then dread the message they have to send.




1. **Before → now**
   Updates as you decide
2. **One decision at a time**
   With an ✨ AI opinion and its reason
3. **Push it back**
   Or hand it over, or put it down
4. **Keep it**
5. **Hard deadlines**
   Listed, never offered

### A swap

Keep what recharges you, drop what doesn't. One tap.

### Someone waiting on it?

Ballast offers to **write the message first** (page 10).

Try it: **Aisyah** → red wall card → **Lighten**.

# Social · try it with real accounts

😩 **THE PROBLEM**

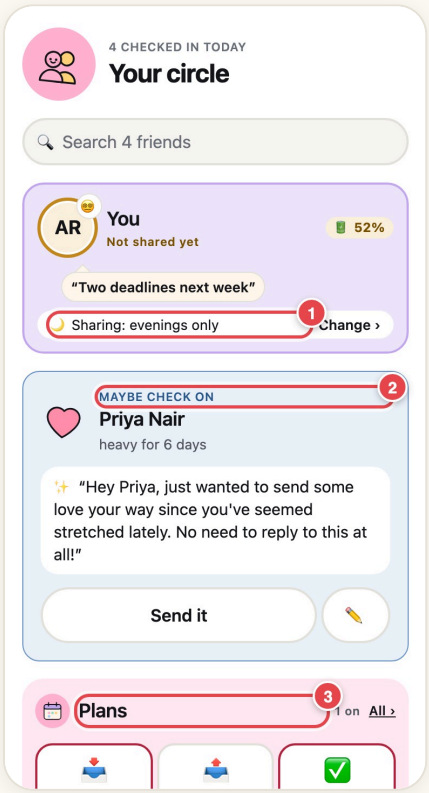
In busy weeks friends drift apart. Nobody knows who's free or who's struggling, and "when are you free?" goes nowhere.

## 🧪 Two accounts, side by side

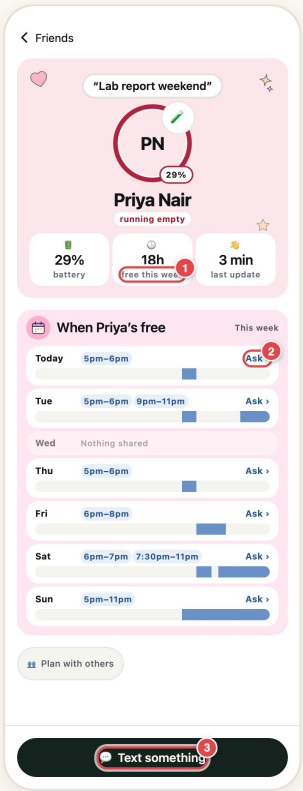
One account per browser: a normal window + a private (incognito) window, or phone + laptop.

1. **Window A:** sign in as Daniel. **Window B:** sign in as Mei Ling.
2. Daniel → **Friends** → **Plan something together** → **Mei Ling** → **Dinner**.
3. Tap the 🟩 **green block** (both free) → **Invite**.
4. Mei Ling → 🔔 **bell** → **Accept**. It lands in her week.
5. Daniel → **Plans** → **Confirmed** → **Add to week**.
6. Bonus: Mei Ling **checks in** with a note → Daniel sees it on **Friends**.

Updates arrive within a minute. Reload to see them instantly.




1. **How much you share**
2. **Maybe check on…**
   A friend having a heavy week
3. **Plans** · received, sent, confirmed




1. **Battery & free hours**
2. **Shared evenings** · tap **Ask**
3. 💬 **Text something** → page 10

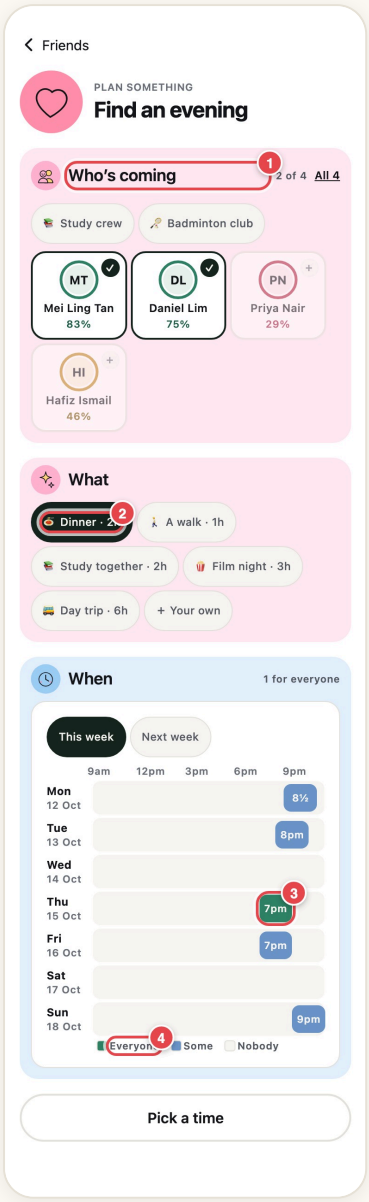


⭐ KEY FEATURE · FROM "WHEN ARE YOU FREE?" TO A PLAN

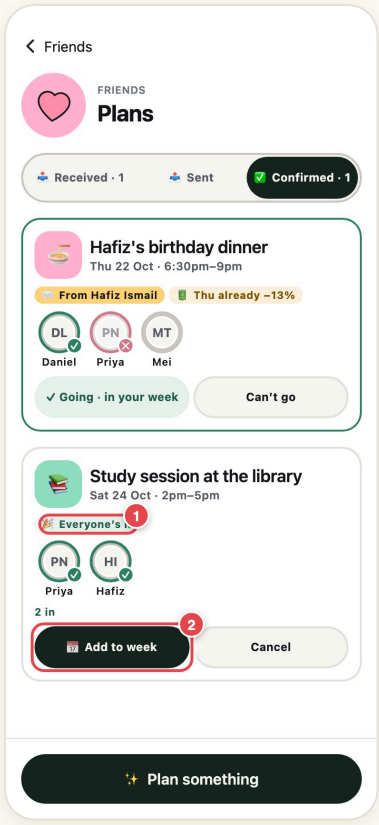
# Social · plan together

😩 **THE PROBLEM**

Finding one evening that works for everyone takes a dozen messages, and plans fall through.




1. **Who's coming** · faces or a group
2. **What** · sets the length
3. 🟩 **Everyone free** · tap it
4. 🟦 **Some free**




1. 🎉 **Everyone's in**
2. **Add to week**
   Once all have answered. Someone can't? **Go ahead with 2.**

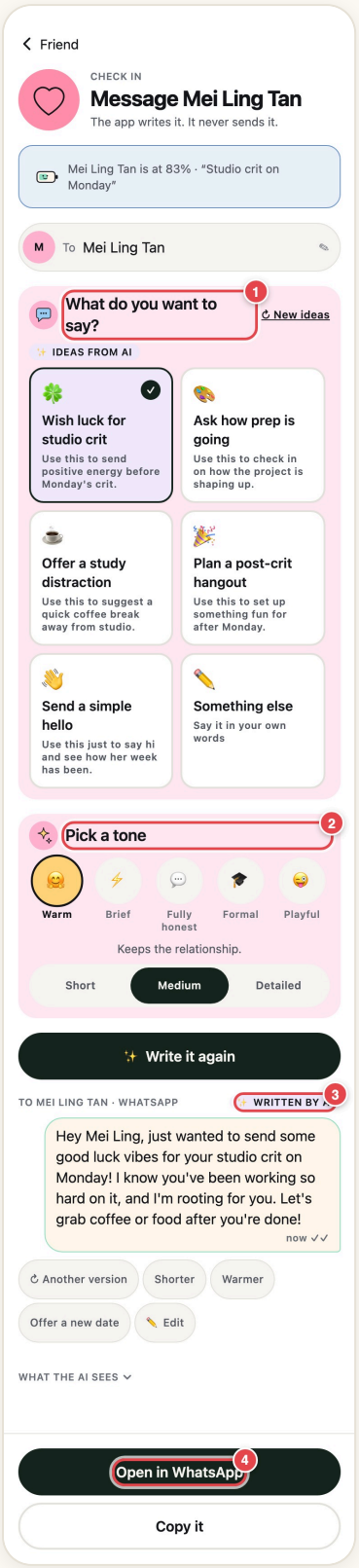
### 📩 Got invited?

See **how full that day already is**, then **Accept**. It goes in your week, moves if the host moves it, and leaves if it's called off.

# Write a message

**😩 THE PROBLEM**

Saying no, or checking on a struggling friend, is the hardest message to write, so it often never gets sent.




1. **What do you want to say?**
   ✨ Ideas that fit them and their week
2. **Pick a tone**
   Warm · brief · honest · formal · playful, and a length
3. ✨ **Written by AI**
   Shorter, warmer, another version, or edit
4. **Open in WhatsApp**
   Or copy it. Ballast never sends anything itself.

## 📍 Where it opens

1. A friend's page → 💬 **Text something**
2. **Maybe check on…** on Friends → ✏️
3. **Saying no**: from Lighten next week, or **Write the message** on the priority list

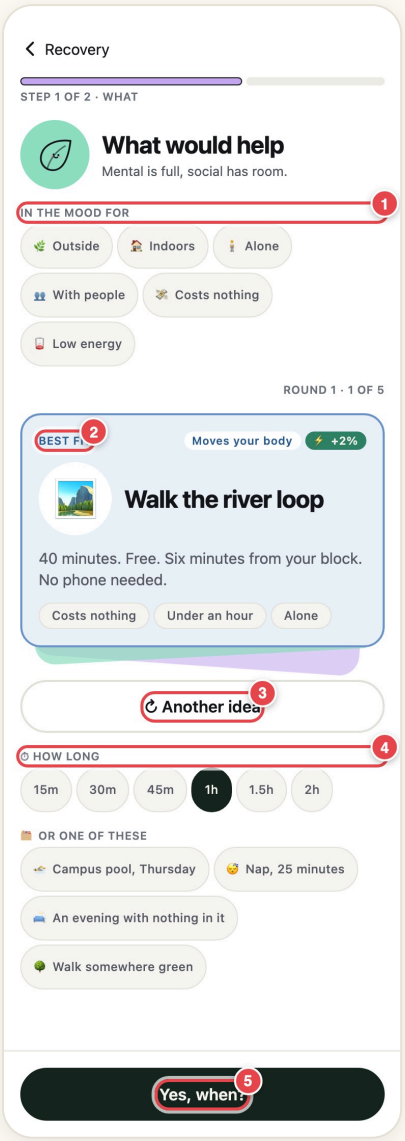
🔒 **What the AI sees** is shown on the page: just what the message is about, never your whole week.

REST YOU CAN ACTUALLY PLAN

# Recovery

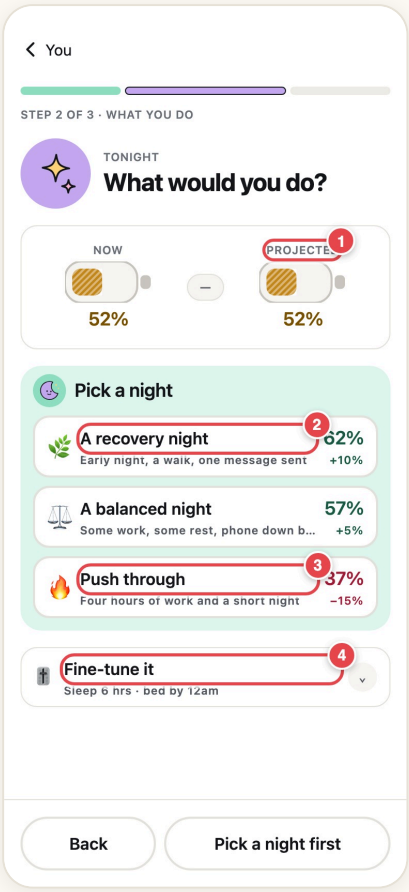
**THE PROBLEM**

Rest is the first thing students drop, and "just rest" isn't a plan.




What would actually help

1. **In the mood for**
   Outside, alone, free, low energy...
2. **Best fit**
   For the area that's fullest, with what it gives back
3. **Another idea**
4. **How long**
5. **Yes, when?** · book it in a real gap




Plan tonight

1. **Now → projected**
   Your battery after the night
2. **A recovery night**
   Early night, a walk: +10%
3. **Push through**
   See what it really costs: −15%
4. **Fine-tune it**
   Sleep and bedtime

**Rest bank:** short sleeps and long days add up to rest you're owed. **Home → rest owed.**

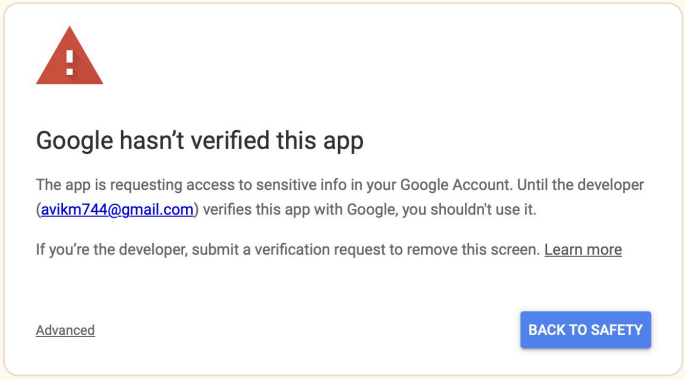
READ-ONLY · EVENTS NEVER STORED

# Google Calendar

**😩 THE PROBLEM**

Your classes and shifts already live in Google Calendar. Typing them in twice is a chore nobody keeps up.

## ⚠️ "Google hasn't verified this app"




1. Tap **Advanced**
2. Tap **Go to Ballast (unsafe)**
3. Allow **read-only** calendar access

**It works fully after that**, and nothing else in the app is affected.

## 🤝 Why: a trade-off

Reading a calendar is a "sensitive" Google permission. Removing this screen needs Google's verification review, which takes weeks. We shipped the feature now rather than leave it out.

## ✨ Once connected

Events become cards, with a guess at what each is (class, deadline, shift). Weekly classes are set up once. Moved events follow.

🙏 Use **your own account** for this, not a judge account.

## 🛟 Known issues & tips

| | |
|---|---|
| **A friend's update isn't there yet** | Sync runs about every minute. **Reload** to see it now. |
| **Judge numbers differ from this guide** | Batteries move as the week goes; others may be using the account. |
| **The demo changed back** | By design: it resets on reload. Demo friends answer by themselves. |
| **An ✨ AI line looks plainer** | If Gemini is busy (free tier), Ballast writes it itself, so nothing breaks. |
| **First load is slow** | The server wakes after idle time. Once, for a second or two. |
| **No App Store version** | It's a web app installed from the link (page 2). Pop-ups work while it's open. |
| **Up to 100 Google accounts** | Google's limit for apps awaiting verification. |

**Thanks for trying Ballast** 🫙 · kcchung82@gmail.com